









**PORTRAITS OF LIFE** (clockwise from far left) 'Santiniketan', 1991; 'My Brother Studying in Hurricane Light at Night', 1956; Spring, 1973; 'Dreaming', 2004; 'Image', 1965

The Dutch painter Piet Mondrian (1872–1944), one of the great innovators of 20th-century abstract art, kept refining his style up until his last active years. Decade by decade, you can see the evolution from his early, figurative paintings to increasingly rarefied levels of abstraction until we reach 1940s works like 'Broadway Boogie Woogie', Mondrian's breathtaking, vertiginous response to New York's skyline. A new retrospective, *Into the Half Light & Shadow Go I*, offers a similar journey covering the stylistic evolution of 84-year-old Jogen Chowdhury, one of India's pre-eminent artists. The show has been curated by Jesal Thacker and Soumik Nandy Majumdar and presented by Kolkata's Gallery Art Exposure.

Like Mondrian, Chowdhury moved gradually towards a higher degree of abstraction after being exposed to the methods of Picasso. But his work—dominated by cross-hatched sketches in pencil and charcoal, and later, sculpture-like supine human figures in watercolour and ink—is informed by a diverse set of influences, not to mention the shifting socio-political realities around him. During an interview, Chowdhury recalled his early years, marked by displacement and resettlement. He was born in Faridpur in 1939 and the family moved to Calcutta upon Partition.

"We left a lot of property in East Bengal," Chowdhury recalled, "and at first, we faced difficulties getting a place to stay in Calcutta. There would be frequent shortages of electricity as well and I would observe people struggling to provide for their families. From the beginning, I was very sensitive to the fact that my art would respond to the physical realities around me." A lot of his early choices as an artist were pragmatic responses to constraints; he made his first sketches by lamplight, his first painting on a wall using colours left over by the local *kumors* (potmakers) on Durga Puja duty. His early works are a mixture of pastoral scenes from Bengal (like a 1956 watercolour called 'A Tiled House', included in the exhibition) and more intimate portraits featuring emaciated, anxious-looking human figures reflecting the struggles he saw firsthand among his fellow refugees.

**At the exhibition, apart from paintings, there are also sketchbooks from every phase of Chowdhury's life**

In 1967, Chowdhury enrolled at the École Nationale Supérieure des Beaux-Arts in Paris. During his Europe years, the painter was exposed to a number of artistic, literary and cinematic movements. *Into the Half Light & Shadow Go I* features many interesting experiments from this phase, like a charcoal portrait of Jimi Hendrix drawn in January 1968, in London, signed by Hendrix himself. "When I was studying in Paris in the late 1960s," Chowdhury said, "I got the chance to travel to England during that time. A friend of mine had a restaurant in London and he told me that the musician Jimi Hendrix would drop by often, so why didn't I come over and maybe make some sketches? So, I went and Hendrix was there along with his girlfriend at the time, Rita Tushingham." The portrait itself is smoky, hallucinatory (in an era-appropriate way), kinetic energy leaping off the lines.

When he's drawing himself (like 'Self Portrait', 1961, included here) Chowdhury eschews glamour for a slow-burning, moody style that reflects his preoccupations—through the 1960s and 1970s, so much of his life was in flux. And that tension between conservatism and reinvention reveals itself in the self-